The *Energiewende*: Green Politics in Germany

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The *Energiewende*: Green Politics in Germany

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I. Introduction

The 21st century has seen a gradual recognition of the importance of green politics. Simultaneously, as climate change has continued to increase in its damage year after year, political parties the world over have begun to embrace green policies, regardless of whether or not they espouse environmentalism in their party platforms. However, as a continent, European states have for decades uniquely contained so-called 'green' political parties: *GroenLinks*[1] in the Netherlands, *Die Grünen/Bündnis '90*[2] ("*die Grünen*"[3]) in Germany, and so on. These parties main mission derives itself from environmentalism, and their influence has proven to be large enough to generate change in European states. So the question is implied: what does the influence of European green parties look like?

European green politics can be best generalized by the policy of Germany's *die Grünen*, which has served as the basis for Germany's transition into a fully renewable economy. As one of the few green parties to gain power in a European parliament, it is incredibly easy to gather information on passed green party legislation in Germany for evaluation. Such green legislation

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[1] English: Green Left

[2] English: The Greens/Alliance 1990

[3] English: the Greens

in Germany makes up what *die Grünen* have coined *die Energiewende*[4]. This paper will examine *die Energiewende* to determine how green policy has succeeded and failed at aiding in Germany's transition from a nonrenewable-based economy into a renewable energy one. Further, the paper will lightly examine how *die Energiewende* has influenced the legislation of green policy at the European Union-level, further supporting the position that *die Grünen* can be used as a generalization for green politics in other European states.

II. Green Politics in Germany

Beginning in 2000, a coalition government in Germany between the Social Democratic Party (SPD) and the Greens introduced the *Erneuerbare-Energien-Gesetz*[5] (EEG) to the Bundestag[6], committing to phase out nuclear power and establish greenhouse gas emissions reduction targets and simultaneous renewable energy targets[7]. This act launched Germany's energy transformation to a "low-carbon, nuclear-free economy," one that is widely known as *die Energiewende*[8].

Initially, the transition was largely focused on the electricity sector, with the federal government in Germany deciding to phase out coal by 2038[9]. Yet, revised climate targets and

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[4] English: the Energy Wave

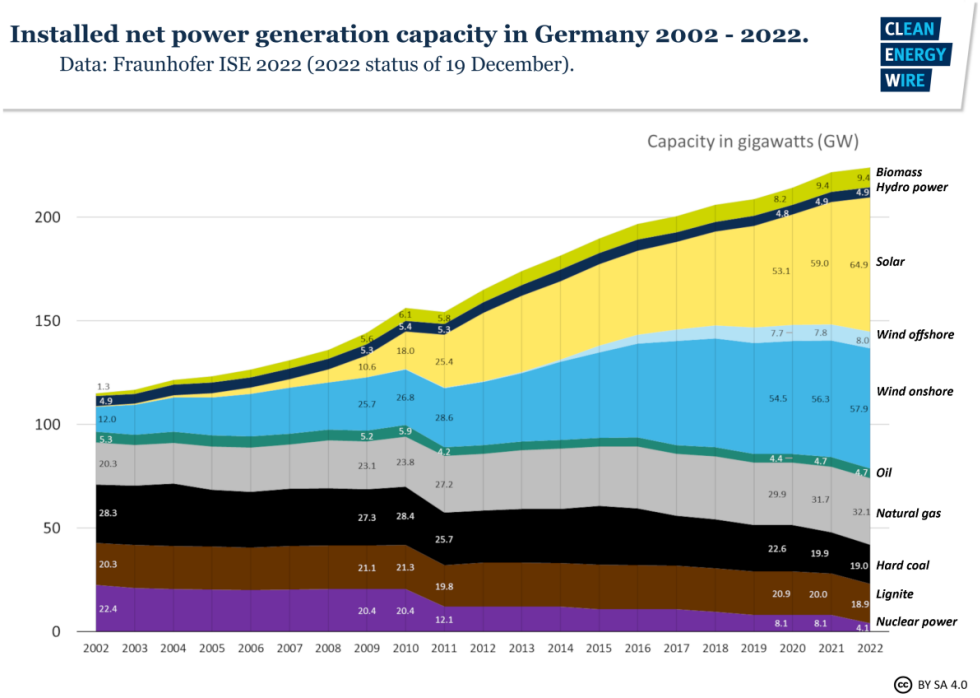
[5] English: Renewable Energy Act

[6] The Bundestag is the lower and more powerful legislative body of the German federal government.

[7] (Cheung, Davies and Bassen, 2019)

[8] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[9] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)



Solar, biomass, hydro, and wind sources generate more power in Germany than fossil fuels (Clean Energy Wire, 2018).

high carbon dioxide prices make an accelerated phase-out likely[10]. Further, large financial support for renewable energy sources—like wind and solar—has made it so that in 2020, for the first time, renewable sources produced more power than fossil fuels in Germany[11]. As Germany operates a social market economy, citizens and cooperatives own many renewable energy installations, but such ownership is gradually shifting to the private and utility sectors, becoming owned by businesses, banks, and German utility bureaus[12].

Simultaneously with its focus on the energy sector, Germany has extended the scope of *die Energiewende*, adding emissions reduction targets for each economic sector and a national

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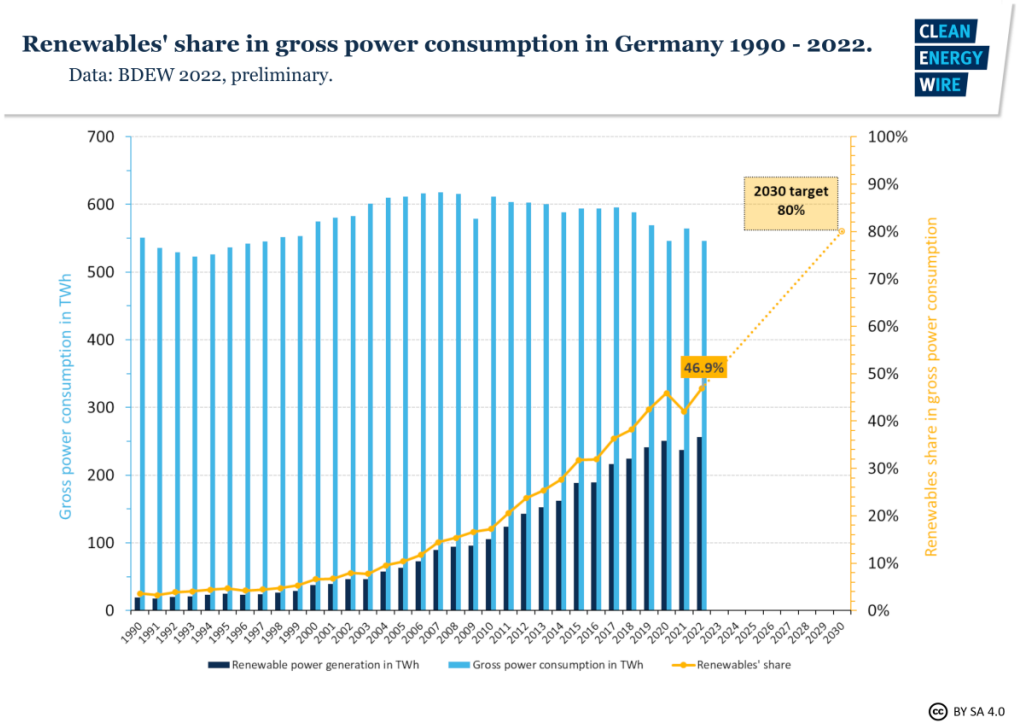
[10] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[11] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[12] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

carbon dioxide price for transport and heating fuels[13]. The aim of the expanding scope of the transition is to power "industry, mobility, and buildings almost entirely with renewables.[14]" Further, the enlarged scope of *die Energiewende* has sought to use green hydrogen to decarbonize sectors where emission reductions are tedious, like heavy industry and aviation[15].

By far the most controversial decision of *die Energiewende* has been Germany's decision to abandon nuclear energy. The country fully gave up nuclear power in 2022, marking the end of the process. Its approach differed widely from its European counterparts[16]. For Germans, though,



Germany is set to surpass its 2030 target of 80% renewable power generation (Clean Energy Wire, 2018).

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[13] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[14] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[15] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[16] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

traumatic reminders of the Chernobyl disaster and inefficiencies in the public energy sector of the former DDR[17] have continued to fuel a fervent opposition to nuclear energy and technology.

By 2016, over 32% of electricity consumption originated from renewable sources, contributing to a reduction in greenhouse gas emissions by 28% below reunification levels in 1990. This benchmark achievement both validated Germany's policy commitment to green politics and made a significant contribution to climate change mitigation via the commercialization of wind and solar technologies, which are now economically competitive with fossil fuels in Germany[18].

Despite such admirable and impressive progress in its climate-friendly politics, Germany continues to struggle in key areas, such as emissions from trucks and passenger vehicles[19]. Further, the challenge of integrating a weather-based system into the power grid poses significant issues for Germany[20]. Yet, the country's proven commitment to mitigating climate change and doing its part generates hope that such challenges can be overcome.

III. Green Politics at the Pan-European Level

The German push for green policy enactment has had broad effects on the policy pursued by the European Union, which has since drafted a so-called European 'Green New Deal'. This legislation attempts to meet three goals: (1) offer guideposts to address the threat to world

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[17] The DDR (*Demokratische Deutsche Republik*) refers to East Germany.

[18] (Cheung, Davies and Bassen, 2019)

[19] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

[20] (Clean Energy Wire, 2018)

ecosystems and aim for explicit targets to "stay within planetary boundaries"; (2) revolutionize fiscal policy by recognizing the link between sustainable investment and social equity; and (3) transform the key systems of energy, transport, housing, and food[21]. Such legislation has broad effects on those living in the European Union and is directly inspired by the slew of reforms enacted by Germany. The policy treats consumers as key players, diverging from former legislation that ignored individuals and cast attention solely on corporations[22]. It further reorients European policy toward systemic solutions rather than relying on so-called 'magic bullet' technologies[23].

IV. Conclusion

As opposed to policy in the United States and elsewhere, Germany—via each and every political party—has pursued a variety of reforms leading to a cleaner and more sustainable economy without compromising its place at the top of world industry. This transformation, known as *die Energiewende*, not only proves to be impressive but also serves as a sign to the rest of the industrialized world of the possibility to decarbonize without de-industrializing and to promote green energy without going bankrupt. The example Germany gives will surely prove vital to other industrialized nations that seek to decarbonize as climate change causes worse and worse disasters to befall Earth in the coming decades.

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[21] (Bloomfield and Steward, 2020)

[22] (Bloomfield and Steward, 2020)

[23] (Bloomfield and Steward, 2020)

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